



The European Union and North Korea: Time for a Strategic Reset?

Author: Patrycja Pyzikiewicz

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Policy brief

Author: Patrycja Oliwia Pyzikiewicz

Hankuk University of Foreign Studies – Introduction to Regional Studies

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Executive Summary

This policy brief examines the European Union's approach to North Korea. It analyses three possible strategies: (1) engagement focused on human security, (2) cooperation for economic or political gain, and (3) passive non-engagement. The brief then evaluates the effectiveness of dialogue and sanctions to date. The paper argues that while sanctions and diplomatic isolation have constrained parts of North Korea's economy, they have not fundamentally changed the country's strategic direction. At the same time, complete disengagement risks further instability and reduces opportunities for humanitarian cooperation.

Key findings:

- Sanctions have not stopped North Korea's nuclear programme.
- Direct EU–North Korea dialogue remains minimal, though humanitarian aid has been provided.
- China and Russia continue to engage economically and politically with North Korea, undermining Western-led pressure.

Recommendation: The EU should maintain targeted sanctions while opening low-level, technical dialogue channels (on humanitarian, environmental, or health issues) to preserve influence and information flow. Isolating North Korea entirely has not worked; selective engagement may offer more leverage.

1. Introduction

How should the international community approach North Korea? The term "approach" can mean different things: maintaining security, pursuing economic or political advantage, or staying passive. These approaches are not mutually exclusive – many countries mix them. This brief analyses each approach and applies it to the European Union's current policy toward North Korea.

2. Three Approaches to North Korea

2.1 Human Security Approach

This approach prioritises preventing nuclear escalation and protecting human rights.

It is motivated by:

- **Security threat:** North Korea's nuclear weapons could destabilise the region and beyond (Bush, 2017).
- **Human rights obligations:** The EU and the US have historically supported human rights causes and may feel obligated to act (US Department of State, 2023).

The EU has provided humanitarian aid to North Korea (KFF, 2011) and supported UN human rights resolutions. However, direct engagement on human rights remains limited.

2.2 Economic and Political Advantage

Some countries cooperate with North Korea for economic or strategic gain:

- **Cheap labour:** North Korean workers have been employed in Europe and elsewhere (Ministerstwo Rodziny i Polityki Społecznej, 2019; Batha, 2016).
- **Natural resources:** Iron ore, coal, magnesium, and seafood (Korean National Statistics, 2022).
- **Political alignment:** Russia and China maintain diplomatic and economic ties with North Korea. Russia has deepened engagement since 2022 (Agence France-Presse, 2023). China is suspected of using North Korean provocations to deflect US pressure on trade (Friedman, 2017).

2.3 Passive Non-Engagement

Some countries stay passive because they have no strategic interest in Korea or are too weak to act. Examples include Switzerland and Singapore (by choice) or Vietnam and the Philippines (by necessity). Poland, for instance, could not easily trade with North Korea without violating EU sanctions (European Council, 2022).

3. Dialogue and Sanctions: Have They Worked?

3.1 Dialogue

Six-party talks (China, Japan, Russia, South Korea, the US, and North Korea) have occurred intermittently since 2003, but North Korea has continued its nuclear programme, conducting six nuclear tests (Davenport, 2022; Grammer, 2022). The EU has not engaged directly in political dialogue with North Korea (38 North, 2020), though it has provided humanitarian aid (KFF, 2011). That aid stopped during the COVID-19 pandemic when North Korea closed its borders.

Conclusion: High-level political dialogue has failed to denuclearise North Korea. Low-level technical dialogue (on health, environment, or disaster response) might still be possible and could build trust over time.

3.2 Sanctions

UN Security Council sanctions (financial, trade, arms) have been imposed on North Korea since 2006 (Wikipedia, 2023). However:

- **Juche ideology** (self-reliance) makes North Korea less vulnerable to external pressure (Wikipedia, 2013).
- **Sanctions harm ordinary citizens** more than the leadership (Jenkins, 2023).
- **Circumvention continues:** China and Russia have been accused of helping North Korea evade sanctions (Wong, 2016).

Conclusion: Sanctions have not stopped North Korea's nuclear programme. They remain a tool, but not a solution. Nevertheless, many policymakers continue to view sanctions as necessary for limiting access to strategic technologies and signalling international opposition to nuclear expansion.

4. The Role of China and Russia

China and Russia are North Korea's main economic and political partners. They have blocked stronger UN action and continue trade and diplomatic exchanges. Any effective EU strategy must account for this reality: isolating North Korea is impossible without isolating its neighbours. The EU should therefore focus on areas where cooperation with China and Russia is possible (e.g., non-proliferation dialogue, humanitarian aid) while maintaining clear red lines on nuclear testing.

5. Policy Recommendations for the EU

Option	Feasibility	Potential impact
Maintain current sanctions	High	Low – already tried
Open low-level technical dialogue	Medium	Medium – could build trust
Engage China and Russia on non-proliferation	Low	High – but politically difficult
Increase humanitarian aid (post-pandemic)	Medium	Medium – improves EU image
Coordinate with South Korea and Japan	High	Medium – avoids mixed signals

Recommended approach for the EU: Maintain targeted sanctions (on nuclear and missile programmes) but open low-level dialogue channels with North Korea on humanitarian, environmental, and health issues. This would preserve pressure while creating engagement opportunities. The EU should also coordinate more closely with South Korea and Japan to avoid mixed signals.

6. Limitations

This brief does not address the internal politics of North Korea in depth, nor does it provide a detailed cost-benefit analysis of specific sanctions. The recommendations are strategic, not operational.

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